CLEO · AI GUIDES

AI Starter Guide

The practical guide to AI tools that save you real time — with specific exercises to try today.

ChatGPT · Claude · Perplexity · Gemini · DALL-E · Midjourney · Notion AI · Otter.ai · Grammarly

Version 2.0 · March 2026 · Not for redistribution

CONTENTS

What's Inside

Nine tools covered in depth. For each one: what it actually does well, honest limitations, and 4–5 specific exercises you can try today.

01 **ChatGPT**
The world's most versatile AI assistant

02 **Claude**
Best for long documents and nuanced writing

03 **Perplexity AI**
AI search that shows you its sources

04 **Google Gemini**
AI woven into Gmail, Docs, Sheets, and Search

05 **DALL-E & Midjourney**
Turn ideas into images in seconds

06 **Notion AI**
AI built into your notes and documents

07 **Otter.ai**
Never take meeting notes again

08 **Grammarly AI**
Real-time writing improvement everywhere you type

09 **Your AI Workflow**
Putting it all together into a daily practice

INTRODUCTION

Before We Start

AI tools are multiplying faster than anyone can track. Most guides either tell you everything is amazing or warn you that everything is dangerous. Neither is useful.

This guide covers the tools that are genuinely ready to use right now — tools that save real people real time in real daily life. For each one you'll find an honest assessment of what it's actually good at, what it struggles with, and specific exercises you can do right now to experience the value yourself.

Because AI is one of those things you don't fully understand until you've used it.

How to use this guide

- Don't try everything at once. Pick one tool. Use it for a week. Then come back.
- The "Try This" sections are the most important part. Do the exercises — don't just read them.
- Your first results won't be great. That's normal. The learning curve is short.
- If a tool doesn't fit your life, skip it. You don't need all of them.

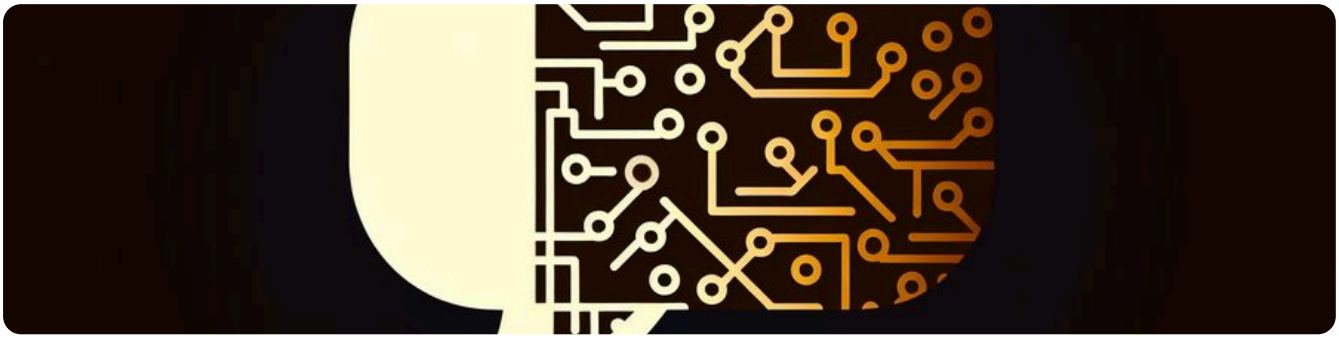
9	45+	2hrs	$0
Tools covered in depth	Specific exercises to try today	Estimated daily time saved once running	Cost to try every tool in this guide

Every tool in this guide has a usable free tier. You don't need to spend anything to work through all the exercises.

01 CONVERSATION & WRITING

ChatGPT

The Swiss Army knife of AI — more capable than most people realise



Free · Plus $20/month chat.openai.com

ChatGPT is the tool that introduced most people to modern AI — and most people are still using 10% of it. They ask simple questions and get simple answers. The real power is in treating it less like a search engine and more like a knowledgeable colleague who has read everything and never gets tired.

What it's genuinely excellent at

- **Drafting and rewriting.** First drafts of emails, proposals, reports. Give it your rough notes and get back polished prose.
- **Explaining complex things simply.** Technical jargon, legal language, medical information — ask it to explain anything in plain English.
- **Brainstorming without judgement.** Unlike asking colleagues, it generates 20 ideas without filtering for what sounds impressive.
- **Code and spreadsheet help.** Write formulas, debug scripts, explain code — even if you've never programmed.
- **Roleplay and scenario simulation.** Practice a difficult conversation, simulate a job interview, rehearse a pitch.

⚡ Try This — 5 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The email rewrite.** Find an email in your drafts that you're not happy with. Paste it into ChatGPT and say: "Rewrite this to be more concise and professional, keeping the same meaning." Compare the output to your original. This takes 90 seconds.
2. **The 20 ideas exercise.** Think of a problem you've been stuck on. Type: "Give me 20 ideas for [your problem]." Don't filter the prompt — let it go wide. Read through all 20. You'll find at least 2–3 you hadn't considered.
3. **The difficult conversation rehearsal.** Think of a conversation you're dreading. Tell ChatGPT the situation and say: "Play the role of [person] and respond to this opening: [your opening line]." Practice until you feel ready.
4. **The jargon translator.** Find a document you've been avoiding because it's dense. Paste a paragraph and say: "Explain this in plain language, like you're talking to a smart non-expert." Repeat for any part you're unclear on.
5. **The meeting prep brief.** Before your next meeting, type: "I have a meeting with [name/role] about [topic]. Give me 5 smart questions to ask and 3 things I should be prepared to answer." Takes 2 minutes. Makes you look well-prepared every time.

Bottom line: Start here if you haven't already. Free tier is genuinely useful. Upgrade to Plus ($20/month) when you find yourself hitting usage limits — which will happen within a week if you use it properly.

02 WRITING & DOCUMENTS

Claude

Better than ChatGPT for long documents, nuanced writing, and careful analysis

Free · Pro $20/month claude.ai

Claude is built around a different philosophy than ChatGPT. Where ChatGPT is the confident generalist, Claude is the careful analyst. It's more thorough in its reasoning and significantly better at handling long documents and complex writing tasks. Its context window — how much text it can process at once — is much larger, meaning you can paste in an entire contract, annual report, or research paper and ask questions about it.

Where Claude pulls ahead of ChatGPT

- → **Long document analysis.** Paste in a 50-page report and ask it to summarise, find key risks, or extract specific data points.
- → **Nuanced writing.** Claude's prose tends to be more natural and less "AI sounding" — better for anything with your name on it.
- → **Following complex instructions.** Give it a detailed brief with multiple constraints; it holds all of them simultaneously.
- → **Reasoning through problems.** Ask it to think through a decision and it gives a more balanced, considered response than most AI tools.

⚡ Try This — 5 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The document summary.** Find a long document you've been meaning to read — an industry report, a lengthy email thread, a policy document. Paste it into Claude and ask: "Summarise this in 5 bullet points, then give me the 3 most important things I should know."

2. **The contract plain-English check.** Take any contract or legal document. Paste a section and ask: "What is this actually committing me to? Are there any clauses that are unusual or that I should pay attention to?" This is not legal advice — but it flags things your eyes might skip.

3. **The decision framework.** Think of a real decision you're working through. Type the situation and ask: "Help me think through this. What are the key factors I should consider? What am I potentially missing?" Use it as a thinking partner.

4. **The tone-match test.** Find a piece of your best writing — something you're proud of. Paste it and say: "Analyse my writing style. Then write a new paragraph about [any topic] in exactly that style." This is how you get AI output that sounds like you.

5. **The research briefing.** Pick any topic you need to get up to speed on. Ask: "Give me a structured briefing on [topic] — what it is, why it matters now, who the key players are, and what someone new to this typically gets wrong."

Bottom line: Use Claude alongside ChatGPT, not instead of it. Claude for documents, reports, and careful writing. ChatGPT for speed, code, and broad tasks. Free tier is enough to evaluate whether it fits your workflow.

03 RESEARCH & SEARCH

Perplexity AI

AI search that shows you where it got its information — the Google upgrade you've been waiting for

Free · Pro $20/month perplexity.ai

The biggest problem with using ChatGPT for research is that it sometimes makes things up — confidently. Perplexity solves this by searching the web in real time and citing its sources. Every claim links back to where it came from. You can click through and verify. Think of it as a research assistant who reads multiple sources, synthesises them into a clear answer, and then shows their work.

Best use cases

- **Current events.** Unlike ChatGPT, Perplexity searches live. Ask about news from this week and it knows.
- **Research with verification.** Need facts for a presentation? Perplexity cites sources so you can check before using.
- **Comparing products or services.** "Compare the top 3 project management tools for small teams" gets a well-sourced, current answer.
- **Follow-up questions.** Ask a question, drill down with follow-ups. It maintains context across the conversation.

⚡ Try This — 5 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The side-by-side test.** Ask Google a research question you've been wondering about. Then ask Perplexity the same question. Compare: which gives you a more useful answer, faster? Most people change their default search habits after this exercise.
2. **The industry briefing.** Ask: "What are the 5 biggest trends in [your industry] in the last 6 months?" Read the answer, then click through to two of the source citations. Takes 10 minutes and keeps you genuinely informed.
3. **The competitor research.** Type: "What are people saying about [competitor name]? What are the main criticisms and praise?" Then follow up: "Who are their main customers?" Research that used to take hours.
4. **The buying decision.** Before your next significant purchase, ask Perplexity: "What should I know before buying [product]? What are common complaints?" Read the sources. You'll make a better decision.
5. **The deep dive.** Pick any topic you're genuinely curious about. Start with a broad question, then use follow-ups to go deeper. Follow the thread for 10 minutes. This is how reading used to work before the internet made it shallow.

Bottom line: Replace Google with Perplexity for research questions. Keep Google for navigating to specific sites. Free tier is sufficient for most people. Pro is worth it if you do heavy research regularly.

04 SEARCH & GOOGLE ECOSYSTEM

Google Gemini

Google's AI — woven into Search, Gmail, Docs, and your whole Google life

Free · Advanced $19.99/month (Google One AI Premium) gemini.google.com

Google Gemini is both a standalone AI assistant and a layer of intelligence running through your entire Google account. If your work and personal life run through Gmail, Docs, Drive, and Calendar — Gemini is the AI that integrates with the least friction. It's already in the tools you use every day.

Where Gemini stands out

- **Gmail Smart Compose.** Gemini suggests full email replies based on thread context. Click "Help me write" and get a complete draft from a one-sentence brief. Works inside Gmail — no copy-paste.
- **Google Docs writing assistant.** Highlight any text and ask Gemini to rewrite, summarise, or extend it — directly within the document.
- **Sheets formula help.** Describe what you want in plain English ("sum only rows where column B says confirmed") and Gemini writes the formula.
- **Multimodal input.** Upload a photo, PDF, or audio file and ask questions about it. Fastest way to extract information from mixed-media sources.

⚡ Try This — 5 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The Gmail reply test.** Open Gmail, find a recent email needing a response. Click "Help me write." Type a one-sentence brief: "Politely decline this meeting request and suggest next week instead." Read the draft, edit if needed, send. This alone saves meaningful time every day.

2. **The Sheets formula rescue.** Open any Google Spreadsheet. Go to Extensions > Gemini. Describe a formula you've always wanted but couldn't figure out: "Average of column C, only for rows where column A contains London." Watch it write the formula for you.

3. **The Docs first draft.** Open Google Docs. Click "Help me write" at the top of a blank document. Type: "Draft a professional bio in 150 words for someone who [describe yourself]." Edit the output. Compare the time it took versus starting from scratch.

4. **The image analysis.** Go to gemini.google.com, click the image icon, and upload any photo — a restaurant menu, product label, whiteboard from a meeting. Ask: "What does this say?" or "Summarise the key information here." Fastest way to extract text from images without a specialist app.

5. **The research comparison.** Take a research question and try it as a normal Google Search, then ask the same question at gemini.google.com. Compare how much time you spent reading to get an answer. For nuanced questions, Gemini synthesises across sources in a way Google search cannot.

Bottom line: If you live in Google — Gmail, Docs, Sheets, Drive — Gemini has the lowest friction of any AI to start using. Free tier is substantial. Upgrade to Google One AI Premium if you use Google Workspace daily and want the full integration unlocked.

05 IMAGE GENERATION

DALL-E & Midjourney

Create any image you can describe — no design skills required

DALL-E: Free via ChatGPT · Midjourney: $10/month chat.openai.com · midjourney.com

Creating custom images used to require a designer or hours of stock photo searching. Now you describe exactly what you want and have it generated in seconds. DALL-E is built into ChatGPT and available on the free tier — access it simply by asking ChatGPT to "create an image of..." Midjourney ($10/month) consistently produces more visually striking, artistic outputs and is worth the cost if you create content regularly.

Prompting well makes a significant difference

- → Be specific about style: "photorealistic", "flat illustration", "watercolour", "3D render"
- → Specify mood and lighting: "warm golden hour light", "dramatic shadows", "bright and airy"
- → Add composition details: "wide shot", "close-up", "aerial view", "minimalist"
- → Reference art styles: "in the style of a vintage travel poster", "corporate photography style"

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The social media image.** Think of your next social post. Ask ChatGPT: "Create a photorealistic image for a post about [your topic]. Clean, professional, bright lighting, wide format." Generate three variations and pick the best. Compare this to how long finding a stock photo takes.

2. **The prompting experiment.** Take one idea and generate it four ways: (1) vague prompt, (2) detailed with style, (3) with specific lighting, (4) with a named art style. See how dramatically the output changes. This teaches you how to prompt effectively in 15 minutes.

3. **The presentation visual.** Find a slide in a presentation that has too many words. Ask DALL-E to create an illustration that captures the key idea visually. Replace the words with the image. Better presentations, faster.

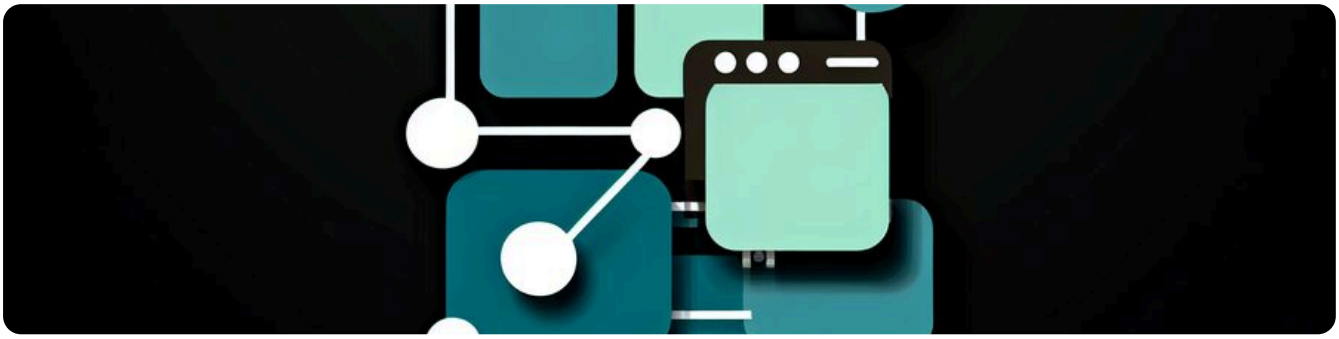
4. **The concept visualisation.** Think of something abstract you need to explain to others. Ask: "Create a simple flat illustration that visualises [concept]." Use it in your next document or email. Visual explanations are understood faster than text ones.

Bottom line: DALL-E (free via ChatGPT) is good enough for most uses. Get comfortable with it first. Upgrade to Midjourney if you create visual content regularly and care about quality. The learning curve for good prompting is about an hour — after that it becomes natural.

06 PRODUCTIVITY & NOTES

Notion AI

AI woven into your notes and documents — no context-switching required



Free trial · $8/month add-on notion.com

If you use Notion for notes or documents, adding Notion AI makes every page intelligent. Highlight any text and ask AI to rewrite it, summarise it, translate it, or continue it. The big advantage over ChatGPT for writing tasks is context: it can see the document you're working in. You don't have to copy and paste anything. That friction reduction matters more than it sounds — it means you'll actually use it.

Best everyday uses

- **Meeting notes cleanup.** Write rough bullet points during a meeting, then ask AI to turn them into a proper summary with action items.
- **First draft generation.** Create a blank document, write a one-sentence brief, then ask AI to generate a first draft to edit from.
- **Page summaries.** Notion AI can summarise any page in your workspace instantly. Useful for revisiting old projects.
- **Q&A across your workspace.** Ask questions about your notes and it answers from your own content.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The meeting notes transform.** After your next meeting, spend 5 minutes writing rough bullet points of what was discussed. Select them all and ask Notion AI: "Turn these into a structured meeting summary with action items, owners, and next steps." Takes 30 seconds and produces a document you'd actually send to people.

2. **The instant draft.** Open a blank Notion page. Type one sentence: what this document needs to say. Then type "/" and select "AI Draft." Give it your brief. Even if you rewrite 70% of it, starting from a draft is significantly faster than starting from blank.

3. **The tone fix.** Find a piece of writing in your Notion that sounds off. Select it and ask Notion AI to "rewrite this to sound more [warmer / more professional / more direct]." Compare before and after. Faster than editing yourself.

4. **The page summary.** Find a long Notion page you created months ago. Click the AI button and ask it to summarise. Get back up to speed in 30 seconds instead of re-reading 10 minutes of old notes.

Bottom line: Only worthwhile if you already use Notion. If you do, it's one of the most frictionless AI integrations available because you never leave your workspace. Don't sign up for Notion just for this — start with ChatGPT instead.

07 MEETINGS & AUDIO

Otter.ai

Never take meeting notes again — Otter joins your calls and handles it

Free (300 mins/month) · Pro $10/month otter.ai

Meeting notes are one of the most tedious recurring tasks in professional life. You're trying to listen, think, and write simultaneously — and you inevitably end up with either poor notes or poor listening. Otter eliminates this completely. Set it up once and it joins your Google Meet, Zoom, or Microsoft Teams calls automatically, transcribes everything in real time, highlights action items, and generates a summary.

The workflow that makes this transformative

- → Connect Otter to your calendar (one-time, 5 minutes). It joins calls automatically.
- → During the call: listen and contribute, not write.
- → After the call: read the AI summary, review action items, share if needed.
- → Search past calls by keyword: "what did we decide about the timeline in March?"

Honest limitations

- → Accuracy drops with strong accents, multiple simultaneous speakers, or poor audio.
- → Always disclose to participants that the call is being transcribed.
- → Not suitable for confidential conversations where recording is inappropriate.

⚡ Try This — 3 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **The setup test.** Sign up for free, connect your Google Calendar, and join your next meeting with Otter active. Inform others at the start: "I'm using an AI transcription tool today." After the call, read the transcript and summary. Judge for yourself whether it's accurate enough to rely on.

2. **The search test.** After a week of use, search for a specific decision or topic from a past meeting. Find it in seconds. Compare that to finding it in handwritten notes — or the common situation where you can't find them at all.

3. **The interview record.** Next time you have a client intake call or any conversation where you need to remember details precisely, record it with Otter (with permission). Use the transcript to follow up with specifics. This level of accuracy in follow-up is rare and impressive.

Bottom line: If you attend 5+ meetings per week, Otter will save you meaningful time within the first week. The free tier (300 minutes/month) covers around 5 hours of meetings — enough to evaluate. Upgrade to Pro if you hit the limit.

08 WRITING EVERYWHERE

Grammarly AI

Real-time writing improvement in every app you use — email, docs, Slack, everywhere

Free · Pro $12/month grammarly.com

Grammarly works across your browser, email client, Google Docs, Microsoft Word, and most apps where you type. It's ambient — it works on everything automatically, without you having to paste text anywhere. The AI features in Pro go well beyond grammar: it rewrites sentences for clarity, adjusts your tone to match the context, detects whether your email sounds too passive or too aggressive, and suggests structural improvements to longer documents.

Features that actually save time

- **Tone detector.** Tells you whether your email reads as confident, frustrated, or apologetic before you send. Catches unintentional tone more reliably than your own read-through.
- **Clarity rewrites.** Highlights hard-to-follow sentences and offers a cleaner version. Accept with one click.
- **GrammarlyGO.** The generative AI assistant built in — ask it to rewrite a paragraph, adjust length, or change the angle, all within your document.

⚡ Try This — 4 Exercises to Do Right Now

1. **Install and draft an email.** Install the Grammarly browser extension (free, 2 minutes). Open Gmail. Draft your next email as normal. Watch what Grammarly flags. Accept the suggestions that improve it. Notice how little friction this adds to your existing process.
2. **The tone check.** Compose an email where tone matters. Look at Grammarly's tone indicator. If it says something different from what you intended, use GrammarlyGO to "make this sound more confident / warm / direct." Trust the detector over your own read.
3. **The passive voice audit.** Take any document you've written recently. Paste it into editor.grammarly.com. Filter for "clarity" suggestions. Count how many passive voice constructions it finds. Rewrite them as active. Most people are surprised how much passive voice they use without realising.
4. **The formality match test.** Use the Grammarly "goals" feature to set your audience and formality level. Write the same message twice — once with "expert audience, formal" and once with "general audience, informal." See how the suggestions change. Use this to calibrate your writing for different recipients.

Bottom line: Free version is worth installing for everyone who writes at work. Pro is worth it if you write frequently or your writing represents you professionally. It's the AI tool that requires the least behaviour change to get value from — it just works in the background.

BRINGING IT TOGETHER

Your AI Daily Workflow

The goal isn't to use every tool every day. It's to have the right tool available when you need it. Here's how a typical day looks when AI is properly integrated into your workflow.

1

PERPLEXITY

Morning catch-up (10 min)

Ask Perplexity: "What happened in [your industry] this week?" Skim the sourced summary. You're informed without reading 12 different sites. Forward anything relevant to colleagues — with context you can generate in 30 seconds with ChatGPT.

2

OTTER.AI

Morning meetings — fully present

Otter runs in the background. You listen, contribute, and think. After the call, you have a complete transcript. The summary takes 2 minutes to review and send to the team with action items.

3

CHATGPT / CLAUDE / GEMINI

Writing and analysis tasks

ChatGPT for quick drafts, emails, and brainstorms. Claude for longer documents and careful analysis. Gemini when you're working inside Google Docs or Gmail and want to stay in one tool. Grammarly runs automatically on everything you write.

4

DALL-E / MIDJOURNEY

Content creation

Need a visual for a presentation, post, or document? Generate it in 2 minutes instead of hunting for stock photos or waiting for a designer. The more specific your prompt, the better the output.

5

NOTION AI

End-of-day notes and planning

Dump rough thoughts, updates, and tomorrow's priorities into Notion. Ask AI to structure them. In 5 minutes you have clear notes and a to-do list — which means you actually close your laptop instead of running thoughts through your head all evening.

WHAT'S NEXT

Where to Go From Here

You now have the foundation. Nine tools, 45+ exercises, and a workflow framework. The one thing that separates people who find AI genuinely useful from those who don't is simple: they actually do the exercises instead of just reading about them.

Pick one tool from this guide. Do one exercise. Today. The rest will follow.

✉

This week

Try the ChatGPT email rewrite on one email you've been procrastinating on.

This month

Set up Otter.ai for meetings. Give it two weeks before judging.

Ongoing

Replace Google with Perplexity for research questions. Notice the difference.

When needed

Reach for DALL-E any time you'd spend 20+ minutes hunting for stock photos.

More guides from Cleo

This is part of a series of practical AI guides — covering tools for musicians, smart home owners, and more. If you found this useful, visit cleoops.com to see what else is available.

More guides
cleoops.com

Questions?
hello@cleoops.com